



theWindow

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Oxygen

Preston Graham



Driving into work recently, I was both surprised and delighted to hear my favorite professor, John Lienhard, begin his usual 8:40 am lecture on WSHU radio. I was anxiously surprised because I knew that I should be hearing his voice in my study at work, well into my day's agenda. I was also delighted because it signaled a break from the mundane hassle of a traffic jam

and transformed my car time into an opportunity to think outside the box.

It was Episode 1515 of *Engines of our Ingenuity*, and the topic was "Oxygen." I will not here retell the story of the discovery of Oxygen (the reader may find the transcript at www.uh.edu/engines/epi1515.htm). Rather, the more fascinating thing was John Lienhard's commentary about the thirty-year discovery process of oxygen as we know it today—a process that began no earlier than in the mid-18th century. How is it that something that is so conceptually clear today was yesterday so vague and mysterious? Lienhard's answer is that the discovery of oxygen demanded nothing short of "wholly new scientific outlook" as described in Thomas Kuhn's 1962 *Structure of Scientific Revolutions*. As Lienhard explains, "oxygen wasn't discovered at all. Oxygen as we know it couldn't have been perceived, much less discovered, until a whole new science was forged to accommodate it." In other words, "pieces of the puzzle added up until an unexpected new puzzle suddenly burst free." And I thought to myself, Lienhard is describing conversion.

Conversion as a "scientific revolution" in the natural or physical sciences involves a whole new science no less than in the spiritual or metaphysical sciences. A whole new way of looking at the universe was required in order to see oxygen, and the same is true of becoming a Christian. To be sure, the apostle Paul viewed conversion as something that could only happen through a supernatural reorientation to life. He describes how "the natural person does not accept the things of the Spirit of God, for they are folly to him . . . because they are spiritually discerned." He also describes how "these things (concerning Christ) God has revealed to us through the Spirit" (see I Cor. 2).

Christianity involves a whole new science, to be sure, one that is imported into our minds and wills by a divine source outside of ourselves, which is why we must pray for conversion, less strive for it. As to the so-called pieces of the puzzle, this new science will necessarily involve a reorientation from an anthropocentric way of thinking about cosmology and life to a theocentric conception. Yes, this starts with a realization that our greatest need is to know God, even as this will mean that God

must make himself known to us. Therefore, the mediums of revelation and illumination become to us the apparatus of our new science—God's word, prayer and sacraments become for the Christian as vital to us as the petri dish, the microscope, and the bunsen burner to the natural scientist. Our discovery will necessarily mean that we make our peace with, and even embrace, our newly discovered dependence as applied then to everything we are in relation to God. Our priorities change. Our ways of seeing the world change. Our practices and methods for living change. Our relationships change. And all these pieces begin to add up until an "unexpected new puzzle suddenly bursts free." How in losing our life in Christ, we gain it! How in receiving God's forgiveness, we extend it. How in being made more holy in Christ, we must humbly confess our lack of holiness. And on it goes, a science wholly foreign to the "natural person" but a new science that is a radical and new way of living!

Have you had this conversion? The apostle John said that there is a sort of "scientific revolution" that is NOT according to the human "engines of ingenuity" but rather according to God's (John 1:13). Have you had this conversion? Are you really so different that you represent a wholly new science or life puzzle? We should pray for this sort of thing to happen in our midst, where the gospel is transforming us, not merely informing us, where things previously vague and mysterious are now exposed in the light of Christ's coming, and where we see no person according to mere flesh and blood, but as either old or new creations depending on their relationship with Christ, so that we might be in the apostolic tradition, proclaiming nothing short of a revolution in Christ and him crucified (I Corinthians 5:16-21).

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Rediscovering Catechism

Jennifer Cheng



It is my distinct pleasure to bring you a taste of the sweet truths, deep history, and persuasive call to reformed teachings that are present in Van Dyken's book, *Rediscovering Catechism: The Art of Equipping Covenant Children*. While the practical focus of the writing is certainly geared toward catechizing children, I urge you to read

for yourselves the well-researched history of catechism and the importance of including catechizing in our homes and churches today. It is rife with Biblical truths and compelling arguments about teaching our children and passing on our tradition of life-changing Scriptural knowledge.

What is catechism?

Catechism is a question-and answer teaching method, meaning literally to "sound down," to speak to someone with the objective of getting something back as an echo. The questions and answers are confessional in nature and should be memorized by both teacher and student (which happens naturally through repetition and review, teaching principles that God himself uses as seen especially in Psalms, Proverbs and Ecclesiastes). As Van Dyken demonstrates, this form of instruction really probes students' understanding, gauges their depth of knowledge, and gives an indication of the state of their heart.

Catechism differs from conventional Sunday School content in that it is based on *word* (hearing and speaking) and a very rigorous and effective learning environment through active participation. While scripture memorization and activities like coloring, pasting, and acting out Bible stories are certainly useful, they do not replace the importance of listening to the Word, asking questions, and getting answers. This reality is nowhere more apparent than in the classrooms of our youth and young adults, where deep questions about God and true ownership of faith need to be addressed. How much better, then, would it be to have already established a foundation of Biblical and doctrinal knowledge from a very early age? Even for us adults, is it not the case in your experience, as it is in mine, that we truly learn and remember when we are given the opportunity to interact with and immediately respond to what we are being taught? In catechizing, your mouth is open, and you are engaging the truth, not merely sitting back while you listen to a lecture.

The spiritual nurture, instruction, and training of children are committed by God primarily to their parents. The home and the church should also make special provision for instructing children in the Bible and church Catechisms. To this end Sessions should establish and conduct Sunday schools and Bible classes and encourage parents of the church to guide their children in the catechizing and disciplining of them in the Christian religion.

—from *The Book of Church Order*, 28-1 and 28-2

Why catechize?

"An obedience born out of love for our Lord Jesus Christ is the primary reason for engaging in any activity" says Van Dyken, and this reason certainly applies to catechizing. Our covenant children today are indeed the next generation in a long line of heirs through which God has promised the continuation of his church. The knowledge Scripture's teachings should be paramount in the content that we teach our children. Should we teach them the Scriptures themselves? Absolutely! Should we teach them specific ways to apply God's truth and Word in their day-to-day lives? Of course! But in between these two steps lies the realm of Biblical interpretation and doctrinal knowledge. Are we to leave our children (or ourselves) at the mercy of our own sinful, selfish, and deceived natures when it comes to the understanding of Scriptural truths? Van Dyken effectively outlines some of the reasons we as Christians have trouble seeing the truth and how the tradition of confessions and catechisms in the Reformed faith (and throughout Biblical history) has helped to preserve the truth of God's Word in the hearts of his people.

"Catechisms, properly written and used, never replace the Bible. On the contrary, they direct our attention to the Bible, excite our interest in its glories, and bring together its truths. As a catechism charts the main features and outlines the grand themes of Scripture, we are led to an orderly understanding. Thus our reading and study of the Bible are more profitable, our life is more fruitful, and our praise and thankfulness to God more intense." —Van Dyken

How do we catechize?

Chapters 8 through 17 outline the actual steps and practical considerations in setting up an effective program for catechizing. This material provides excellent ideas for parents and churches who desire to incorporate catechizing into their teaching. Catechizing is vital in our covenant community today, and we can begin at an earlier age than is often thought. Without going into too much detail, the church is responsible for teaching the Scriptures and confessions and then choosing the catechism to be used in the church. Then the responsibility is on the parents to teach their children the content of the catechism at home. (This responsibility surely applies to uncatechized adults, as well!) Finally, the church must appoint qualified teachers to carry out classes that will support parents and ensure that they are fulfilling their primary role. All this happens with the desired end of giving children the deep, personal knowledge of who God is, his sustaining love and grace, and the joy of the covenantal relationship that they enjoy with him through Christ Jesus.

I would encourage you not only to take the time to read this book for yourselves, but then also to consider whether catechism should perhaps hold a more prominent place in your life and the life of your church and what you could do to further that end.

Training Hearts, Teaching Minds by Starr Meade is an excellent companion to Van Dyken's book, comprising over two years' worth of family devotions on the Westminster Shorter Catechism. Both books are available in the CPC bookstore.

The Arts Celebration

Dan Kellogg



On February 6, 2003 we held our second ever CPC Arts Celebration. In God's great sovereignty He sent us a day of dreadful snow, but a reduced audience was able to slog through the drifts for a blessed evening.

The music team sponsored the first Arts Celebration a couple of years ago to create an evening when our church community came together to enjoy each others' artistic gifts. These gifts came in many forms and abilities. Children played a variety of instruments with pieces ranging from "Twinkle, Twinkle" to masterpieces of classical music. Adults surprised us with unexpected gifts. Everyone got a good laugh when Cliff Bogue graced us with some clog dancing. Amateur photographers Dan Deacon and Lei Chen brought samples of their work. Shi-jen Cheng played the piano while Jennifer played the saxophone. The Shields dressed in Panamanian folk attire and performed a traditional dance. The evening also featured many outstanding performances from our professional musicians. All in all, it was a spectacular event.

The evening provided great entertainment, but it meant so much more than that. It embodied a spirit of celebration and enjoyment of the arts. Our catechism teaches us that we are to enjoy God. Every time I see "Chariots of Fire" I am moved to tears when Eric Little says "when I run, I feel God's pleasure" (imagine Scottish accent). Enjoying the arts is enjoying the beauty of God's creation and enjoying the part of our own nature, made in His image, that is programmed to respond to beauty. In the words of John Hardie, "sweet."

The evening was also a great "family" time. Individuals offered their gifts to the community and the community responded with love and thanksgiving. Many children stepped on to the stage for the first time. The encouragement they received is often worth more than we could ever know. Some adults stepped back onto the stage after many years away, and the professionals shared the stage in love and admiration. Every participant was responded to with love as a precious member of our body in Christ. We truly felt like a family.

This year's event was just as precious. Many children took their instruments and fearfully walked up to the stage to play. There were simple tunes like "Hoe-down" and "Minuet," but in each case, for a few brief moments the eyes of the whole church were fixed on them as they offered up the fruit of their labors. For some, it may have been the first time they received applause. For others, it was another step in the long and disciplined process of studying a musical instrument. My prayer is that it was an affirmation of the great love this church has for each of them and that it is a taste of what it means to offer one's gifts up to the Lord and to a church.

Many adults who performed created quite a great stir. Janine Lempke sang a very moving song with deeply personal lyrics. Joe Shields and Bill & Hannah Cerynik performed a song that Joe and Bill had written together. We also heard from Hsing-ay (piano), Michelle (violin), Vince (clarinet), and Joe (classical guitar). Caitlin read a poem from T. S. Eliot's collection on cats. Lei, Dan Deacon, and Barbara all displayed their photos.

There were two performances that rang out as unexpected delights. Four Zitzmans performed a short piece and the three children performed without music. It was an awesome sight to see this family make music together. Harry Dozier, a junior at Yale, sang two pieces: the first was in a cappella gospel style and the second was the James Brown tune "I Got the Feeling" in an old funk style. Of course he was backed up by some outstanding performers, as Joe, Hsing-ay, Bill, Michelle, and I joined him on our instruments. I assure you it was quite a spectacle.

I had great pleasure in planning and attending this event. The arts are a wonderful gift that can nourish us in many ways at different points in our lives. When next year's calendar comes out, please put this evening in your date book right away. Don't miss an opportunity to support our kids & families, have a great evening of entertainment, and possibly bless us with *your* gifts!



Kids enjoy making music at a recent church event.

The Servant Leader Board

Sam Newlands



Have you ever had one of those moments of clarity when the deeper significance of what you were doing suddenly dawned on you . . . only to realize later such "insight" was mistaken? Recently, I had such an experience as part of the Servant Leader Board. Let me explain.

The moment occurred during our February board meeting, a monthly event when team leaders and congregational representatives gather to discuss what, quite frankly, are often mundane and small matters relating to the weekly running of the church. Sure, there are occasionally big issues that we are asked to consider and pass recommendations on, especially around the time of budget planning. But more often than not, our meetings are filled with deliberations over the minutia of church life. Should we recommend the purchasing of new bulletin boards? Should we move the women's brunch to April? Will it overtax the congregation to have three events on one weekend? Do the ushers in the first service need to stand in the front during Communion, or is that only necessary once a month in the second service? Such are the types of questions that normally occupy our discussions, and I confess that during the course of the three- to four-hour meetings, it is quite tempting, for me at least, to lose sight of the bigger reasons for why we should consider diligently and thoroughly the optimum time for the next fellowship meal.

It was during such a recent discussion of whether or not to move the next board meeting that one of the members announced that she would be unable to attend because of an upcoming surgical procedure. Needless to say, the room quieted into a stunned silence, the date of the next meeting seeming suddenly quite unimportant. We moved immediately into a time of prayer, and another member shared her own medical concerns, adding urgency to our petitions. As the shock wore off later that evening, I *thought* I had a moment of clarity. “There,” I said to myself, “was a truly *significant* moment in the meeting. The rest of the discussion was really just stage-setting for the opportunity to pray for these two people.” Or so I had thought.

I’ve since come to think that I was somewhat mistaken in this assessment. It is certainly true that the time the board spends in intercessory prayer is of paramount importance to the spiritual vitality and growth of its members. It is also true that, as board members called to serve Christ and His church, we ought to be ever-mindful of the physical and spiritual needs of those around us. But what about my related thought, that the “mundane stuff,” the monthly decisions and recommendations about service logistics, building usage, calendar scheduling, etc. wasn’t *really* spiritually important? Was I right in assigning some sort of secondary status, at best, to these matters? I don’t believe so.

The purpose of the Servant Leader Board is ultimately to glorify Christ in His church, a purpose that requires enabling the people of God to assemble, worship, and minister, one to another. This task is important and daunting, and the fact that it sometimes takes the form of what I was tempted to dismiss as seemingly



The church celebrates John Hardie's ordination to the office of Teaching Elder.

ancillary decisions in no way diminishes the significance and calling of the board’s efforts. Our goal is to provide an environment in which people can make genuine connections with each other, in the hopes that CPC will become, more and more, one body in Christ. Sometimes meeting that goal indeed takes the form of praying for the needs of those around us and earnestly investing our lives in each other. But sometimes it takes the form of hammering out a recommended building usage policy. It is my hope and prayer that God will be glorified in *all* such endeavors.



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